

Govt spark likely for long energy storage

/ Adani eyes an Apple model / More teasers Fuel for thought: Can India drive on 100% ethanol? u P10 Temper expectations, Kotak's Bharkada tells investors u P4 SENSEX 75,238 0.00 OIL \$107.65 \$2.43 could also consider interest subven- tion support to improve liquidity access and accelerate adoption. "Heavy reliance on short-duration storage could reduce energy secu- rity, increase system costs, and limit the feasibility of achieving 100% These include pumped hydro stor- age, flow batteries, compressed air energy storage (CAES), and sensible heat storage. A viability gap funding (VGF) mechanism for LDES is currently being worked out, one of the officials said, adding that the government Manas Pimpalkhare & Rituraj Baruah India is scrambling to solve a growing clean-energy paradox: the country is adding renewable power at a record pace, but it lacks the storage capacity needed to use that energy when the sun sets and wind generation drops. To bridge that gap, the Union gov- ernment is preparing a financial sup- port scheme for long-duration energy storage (LDES) technologies, according to three people aware of the discussions. The proposed scheme-part of the government's 'India Battery Storage Vision 2047'-is being worked out by the ministries of power and heavy industries, and is expected to be rolled out by fiscal year 2028 (FY28) under the admin- istrative control of the power minis- try, the people said on condition of anonymity. The push comes as policymakers increasingly acknowledge that India cannot fully leverage its rapidly expanding renewable-energy capac- ity without large-scale storage infra- structure. Unlike battery energy storage sys- tems (Bess), which typically store electricity for one to four hours, LDES technologies can supply Support for long-duration energy storage to aid green powerGovt spark likely for long energy storage Samsung, camera parts from Sony, chips from TSMC, and it gives the parts to Foxconn to assemble. That's why Apple could scale," the person cited

above said. "The Adani Group is creating an extended enter- prise environment like Apple has." Adani, the richest Indian as per Bloomberg Billionaires Index, is himself overseeing the changes that have been in the works for over three years, the first person said. It was partly triggered by the group becom- ing too large to manage, raising concerns about a growth slow- down. The Ahmedabad-based con- mumbai Billionaire Gautam Adani is looking to outsource vast swathes of the group's operations to its ven- dors while conserving manage- ment bandwidth for strategy, research and finance, following the global playbook of multina- tionals such as Apple and Hyundai, which rely heavily on contract manufacturing to scale rapidly. The move is part of a larger strategy to promote internal talent and an create easier organizational structure, two people aware of the devel- opment said. The ports-to-renewable energy conglomerate is aggres- sively developing a third-party vendor ecosystem to take over manufacturing, logistics, engi- neering and other functions, the people said on the condi- tion of anonymity. It is also compressing its corporate structure into three layers to speed up decision-making. It has also set up a programme to promote internal talent with an emphasis on prioritizing inter- nal promotions over lateral hir- ing. "Apple gets Gorilla Glass from Corning, screen from Adani eyes an Apple model to scale up rapidly via vendors Gautam Adani, chairman of Adani Enterprises. AFP POWER PLAY BATTERY VISION LDES technologies can supply power for eight hours or moreThese include flow batteries, pumped hydro storage, CAESA VGF mechanism for LDES is currently being worked outNIFTY 23,643.5 0.00 DOLLAR ₹95.97 ₹0.00 EURO ₹111.59 ₹0.00 POUND ₹128.09 ₹0.00 ISTOCKPHOTO

Uber's chief executive Dara Khosrowshahi. Nehal Chaliawala & Satish John mumbai Uber Technologies CEO Dara Khosrowshahi is no stranger to difficult transitions. The executive who steered Expedia through rapid expansion and took Uber pub- lic has spent nearly a decade reshaping the ride-hailing giant. In an interview, he said India occupies a unique place within

Uber's global portfolio, given its long-term potential. "We could turn a profit here in India," he said, "but it would be selling our business and the potential of this country short." FULL INTERVIEW ON P6 Rapido has innovated, we did it faster , says Uber CEO INTERVIEW mUK's Prudential Plc said it plans to buy 75% stake in Bharti Life Insurance and then cut its holding in ICICI Prudential Life Insurance to 10%. It will buy the stake from Bharti Life Ventures and 360 ONE Asset Management for ₹3,500 crore. >P3 Prudential to buy 75% in Bharti Life Insurance for ₹3,500 crore Youngsters riding bikes at high speed without hands on the handlebars and performing stunts have long been a common sight in India, raising serious safety concerns for both riders and other motorists and even pedestrians. >P2 New two-wheeler norms in works to curb hands-off riding The Centre is set to clamp down on the use of harmful chemicals and energy-intensive processes in the pharmaceutical industry, a sweeping regulatory shift that will alter how medicines are tested and manufactured in India's \$50 billion drug market. >P2 Govt plans clean-up of toxic chemicals in drug-making DON'T MISS ISTOCKPHOTO The Media Marketing Initiative on Page 3 is the equivalent of a paid-for advertisement, and no Mint journalist was involved in creating it. Readers would do well to treat it as an advertisement. NOTE TO READERS 15.00 . Price with Hindustan Times Rs. 20.50 18 pages

Page 6:

Govt plans clean-up of toxic chemicals in drug making

/ Monsoon advances towards Kerala / Two-wheeler safety norms / FASTags for toll-exempt vehicles / Govt digitizes green nod / Straight Forward column 02MONDAY , 18 MAY 2026 CORRECTIONS AND CLARIFICATIONS Mint welcomes comments, suggestions or complaints about errors. Readers can alert the newsroom to any errors in the paper by emailing us, with your full name and address to It is our policy to promptly respond to all complaints. Readers dissatisfied with the response or concerned about Mint's journalistic integrity may write directly to the editor by sending an email to Mint's journalistic Code of Conduct that governs our newsroom is available at FOR ANY QUERIES/DELIVERY ISSUES chemicals in drug making Pharmacopoeia commission crafts new standards incorporating green chemistry principles posed measures expected to increase prices by ₹800-1,000 per unit for installing sensors on handlebars, at least two industry executives said. The move marks a fresh push by the Centre to tighten two-wheeler safety norms even as The shift towards a green pharmacopoeia is expected to have a broad impact on public health by ensuring a cleaner manufacturing cycle. BLOOMBERG Ayaan Kartik & Manas Pimpalkhare Youngsters riding bikes at high speed without hands on the handlebars and performing stunts have long been a common sight in India, raising serious safety concerns for both riders and other motorists and even pedestrians. This could soon change. The government is planning a three-layer "hands-free" safety system for two-wheelers, requiring manufacturers to install technology that can detect whether riders have both hands on the handlebars and step in if they do not, amid rising road accidents in the country.

According to an internal draft of the proposal, reviewed by Mint , the planned safety standards would require bikes and scooters to prevent ignition without both hands on the grip, issue audio and visual alerts if hands are removed while riding, and gradually slow down the vehicle in such cases. The introduction of new standards will lead to additional costs for automakers, which are typically passed on to consumers, with the pro-its attempt to mandate anti-lock braking systems (ABS) across all categories of two-wheelers irrespective of engine capacity remains stuck amid industry resistance and cost concerns. Mint first reported in July last year that the Centre had begun working on a plan to curb hands-off driving in two-wheelers. "There have been deliberations with the government on this where we have discussed a range of features that can be introduced on two-wheelers. The Automotive Industry Standards Committee has prepared a set of regulations and test procedures to crack down on people removing hands while driving," the senior executive cited above said on the condition of anonymity. "Any price increase could have an adverse impact on demand, especially when coupled with an increase in fuel prices. However, regulations that do not lead to an adverse sticker shock could see a lower impact on demand," said Ashim Sharma, senior partner and business unit head at Nomura Research Institute Consulting and Solutions, India. Consultations between the government and automobile manufacturers in 2025 on increasing road safety involved discussions about whether the industry could introduce features on vehicles to reduce accidents, at a time when the government had indicated its view to mandate the use of ABS, Mint reported in July 2025. AISC works under the aegis of the ministry of road transport and highways and prepares standards, which are then approved by Central Motor Vehicle Rules Techni-

cal Standing Committee. ayaan.kartik@live-mint.com

New two-wheeler safety norms in works to curb hands-off riding

The government is planning a three-layer 'hands-free' safety system for two-wheelers. MINTSubhash Narayan The Centre is developing a separate category of FASTags for toll-exempt vehicles as part of its nation-wide rollout of barrier-free highway tolling under the Multi-Lane Free Flow (MLFF) regime, according to two people aware of the matter. The proposed system is expected to allow exempted users, including armed forces personnel and certain government agencies, to pass through toll corridors without being charged or flagged for violations, the two people said. The move is aimed at addressing a key challenge in India's shift to artificial intelligence (AI)-enabled tolling systems, where every vehicle passing through a toll point must be digitally identified and recorded. Mint had earlier reported on the government's plans to shift to MLFF tolling, which uses AI, satellite-based tracking and automatic number plate recognition systems to collect tolls electronically while vehicles continue moving at high speeds. But the system creates compliance challenges for creating a centralized database of exempted vehicles with the ministry of road transport and highways (MoRTH), enabling back-end integration with the tolling system. The second involves issuing dedicated FASTags carrying unlimited free-pass privileges to authorized agencies, the second person cited above said. Queries sent to MoRTH, the National Highways Authority of India and the defence ministry remained unanswered till press time. Former defence and road transport secretary Giridhar Aramane said the government had already conducted pilots involving exempted institutions such as the armed forces, police and paramilitary agencies, where vehicle databases were integrated with tolling

systems for smooth passage. "The new system brings about challenges for toll treatment of private vehicles used for official purposes that are also in the exempted category. Either details of these vehicles can also be shared with MoRTH or the ministry could issue special FASTags with infinite free movement," he said. The move is aimed at addressing a key challenge in India's shift to AI-enabled tolling systems. ISTOCKPHOTO exempted categories such as defence, paramilitary, and police vehicles. Any unregistered or unrecognized vehicle movement through toll points could automatically trigger e-challans or penalties even in cases where the vehicle is legally toll-exempt. Exempted vehicles could carry specially configured FASTags capable of automatically registering vehicle movement without deducting toll charges, the first person said. Official military vehicles, however, may not require FASTags at all. Their movement through tolling points could instead be tracked through recognition of special defence number plates, with the associated movement data deleted immediately afterwards for security reasons, the person added. To address the issue, the government is evaluating two approaches. One involves sharing—Under the proposed system, every vehicle passing through a toll point will be digitally identified and recorded. Vijay C. Roy & Manas Pimpalkhare The government has digitised the compliance process for environmental clearances linked to industrial expansion, in a move aimed at easing regulatory burdens and accelerating project

approvals, said two officials aware of the development. The ministry of environment, forest and climate change has made the process of obtaining certified compliance reports for industrial expansion proposals digital through the existing PARIVESH portal, aiming to ease procedures for businesses seeking environmental clearance. Launched in August 2018, PARIVESH (Pro-Active and Responsive facilitation by Interactive, Virtuous, and Environmental Single-window Hub) is a central government digital platform, which automates and streamlines the process for businesses and developers to apply for and track mandatory environmental and ecological clearances. The online system will enable industries to file compliance reports pertaining to

projects where environmental clearance is needed, upload mandatory documents and track approval status through a single digital platform, reducing paperwork and procedural delays, the officials said, requesting anonymity. "It will be useful for those projects which require environmental clearance. The move will benefit medium and large scale industries as the entire process can now be completed online. Once all the documents are uploaded, ministry officials will conduct on-site inspections and geo-tag the premises, a move that is also expected to enhance transparency in the system," said the first official cited above. The move is aimed at easing regulatory burdens and accelerating project approvals, said two officials. Priyanka Sharma

The Centre is set to clamp down on the use of harmful chemicals and energy-intensive processes in the pharmaceutical industry—a sweeping regulatory shift that will alter how medicines are tested and manufactured in its \$50 billion drug market. The Indian Pharmacopoeia Commission (IPC) is crafting new standards for drug making and testing by using green chemistry principles, which are essentially guidelines to reduce or eliminate hazardous substances. The commission is the health ministry's apex body responsible for setting the standards for drug making and testing in India. A key objective is to replace carcinogenic class-1 solvents such as benzene, chloroform and carbon tetrachloride with water or other safer class-3 solvents, two people aware of the matter said on condition of anonymity. The commission has started with high-volume categories, one of the two people said. "The IPC has already updated approximately 25 monographs within the IP (Indian Pharmacopoeia) 2026 edition, focusing on high-volume categories such as anticancer, antihypertensive and antibiotic drugs. It is now working on an additional 50 monographs under this 'green' framework to further expand the initiative," the person said. A monograph outlines the tests a drug must pass to prove its identity, purity, and strength before it can be sold. The shift towards a green pharmacopoeia is expected to have a broad impact on public health by ensuring a cleaner manufacturing cycle. It also assumes significance for global medicine use, given that Indian companies supply 20% of the world's generic medicines and account for 60% of global vaccines. Apart from India, these standards are also followed in 14 more countries—Afghanistan, Ghana, Nepal, Mauritius, Suriname, Nicaragua, Bhutan, Mozambique, ~25 Monographs within IP 2026 that IPC has already updated. bique, the Solomon Islands, Sri Lanka, Nauru, Malawi, Guyana and Fiji. "The IPC is working on environmental sustainability and ecofriendly standards. If these methods are adopted into the IP, hundreds of manufacturers across India will cumulatively save thousands of litres of hazardous solvents," the second person

said. The IPC is also utilizing research and innovation to optimize testing processes. By reducing the number of procedural steps and shortening testing times—for instance, achieving results in five hours rather than 10—the commission aims to save significant resources and energy. "These changes are meticulously evaluated to ensure that drug quality remains uncompromised and results remain reproducible. The initiative also extends to the physical and digital footprints of the commission. The IPC has already moved toward a digital-first IP to reduce paper consumption and is now transitioning its Indian Pharmacopoeia Reference Substances (IPRS) packaging to fully recyclable materials, the second person said, adding the new standards will also limit the flow of discarded toxic chemicals into soil and water. Queries emailed to a health ministry spokesperson remained unanswered. The Indian Pharmaceutical Alliance (IPA), which represents 23 leading pharmaceutical companies, welcomed the move. "The IPA has consistently advocated for integrating green chemistry and scientifically validated alternatives to animal testing into regulatory frameworks. To ensure seamless adoption, the implementation of these methodologies must remain science-driven, globally harmonized, and pragmatically phased. This approach will guarantee analytical consistency, reproducibility, and cross-border regulatory acceptance, while upholding the highest standards of drug quality, safety, and efficacy," secretary general Sudarshan Jain said.

Other countries that also follow Indian standards Freedom can never be taken for granted. It always requires awareness, strength and austerity. I invite all of you to whatever religion or party or group you may belong to as comrades in this great struggle that has been forced upon us. I have full faith in our people and in the cause and in the future of our country..." Jawaharlal Nehru gave this speech on All India Radio on 22 October 1962 after China's attack. There was a massive response by the people to his call to action. The secessionist movement in Tamil Nadu stopped. In one Rajasthan village, 250 families pledged to send their sons to the army. All strikes and movements were suspended. Women bought wool from the money saved in their piggy banks, rice canisters or trunks to knit sweaters for soldiers. My mother was one of them. Many women donated their mangalsutras to the government treasury for military equipment purchases. Among those donating was Nehru's only child, his daughter, Indira Gandhi. She donated her entire jewellery weighing 367gm to the war fund. Within three years India faced another tough test. In 1965, US

President Lyndon B. Johnson delayed our wheat supply. In response, Prime Minister Lal Bahadur Shastri appealed to his countrymen to forgo meals once a week to save grain. I was in primary school. I remember that on Tuesday evenings flatbread and a simple vegetable would be cooked for us children. My parents and grandfather would observe a fast. Today, when the entire world is suffering due to the crisis in West Asia, I am once again reminded of the 1973 embargo in the region. Relations deteriorated between the Gulf countries and the US. It led to an energy supply breakdown. For India, those were tough times. Indira Gandhi had to raise the price of petrol from ₹1.60 per litre to ₹2.75 per litre. The Centre's budget that year was termed the 'Black Budget'. The country suffered an unprecedented loss of ₹550 crore. The war with Pakistan, the influx of refugees from Bangladesh, the 1972-73 drought and a surge in defence spending strained both the government and its citizens. What a strange coincidence that the meteorological department has predicted a below-normal monsoon this year and the Gulf crisis has set oil prices on the boil. There's a world of difference between the situations of 1973 and today. Then, there were just 650,000 motor vehicles in India. Today, the number stands at 400 million. At that time, only 4,055km railway was electrified and 80% of the trains ran on coal or diesel. Today, electrification of railways is near 100% and diesel engines are maintained just for strategic use. Despite these gains, the needs of 1.4 billion people have surged. Energy demand today is many times higher than in 1973. As a result, the petrochemical industry's daily losses have crossed ₹1,000 crore. Yet, the government kept petrol and diesel prices in check, raising them only marginally on Friday. India is the only nation providing free rations to 800 million. This comes at a time when the rupee is hitting record lows against the dollar and euro amid weakening global trade. Energy prices may rise further in the near future. It is difficult to understand the criticism when Prime Minister Narendra Modi is urging restraint in energy use, advising a pause on gold purchases and discouraging unnecessary foreign travel at a time like this. I don't want to waste my time on politicians and their politics. Their tone changes according to the tide of time. In 1962, our country faced extreme challenges due to Chinese aggression. At the time, Atal Bihari Vajpayee was sharply criticising Nehru's policies in Parliament. Later, he reflected on his stance and, during the 1971 Bangladesh War, praised Indira Gandhi as "Durga." The same Vajpayee later became prime minister. Even today, he's considered a beacon of Indian politics. But other leaders didn't learn any lessons from him. During 1962, '65 and '71, those who attacked the Congress are now in power and the Congress is in the opposition. Now, their leaders are attacking the Bharatiya Janata Party. The way politics has panned out leaves everyone sad. How can our politicians change their stance with such consummate ease? It's unfortunate that their conduct is leading to dismay. In 1999, when the forces were moving during the Kargil conflict, there was no one at railway stations offering them packed food chanting "Bharat mata ki jai". Between 1962 and 1971, the same society would

chant patriotic slogans when trains with soldiers would pass. The partisan narratives seen during Operation Sindoor felt like a warning of what may lie ahead. Are we drifting towards declining patriotism and a weakened collective conscience? If yes, can the trend be reversed? Shashi Shekhar is editor-in-chief, Hindustan. Views are personal. How can our politicians change stance with such consummate ease?

STRAIGHTFORWARD SHASHI SHEKHAR IS INDIA'S NATIONAL UNITY SLOWLY WEAKENING? Respond to this column at Vijay C Roy India's weather office on Sunday said conditions are turning favourable for the further advance of the south-west monsoon over parts of the south-east Arabian Sea, south-west and south-east Bay of Bengal, the remaining areas of the Andaman Islands and Andaman Sea, and parts of the east-central Bay of Bengal over the next two to three days, even as large parts of north and central India brace for intensifying heatwave conditions. The south-west monsoon is likely to reach Kerala on 26 May, close to its normal onset date of 1 June, according to the latest forecast by the India Meteorological Department, which has projected a model error margin of four days on either side. Last year, the monsoon reached the Kerala coast on 24 May. A timely monsoon is critical for kharif sowing, especially for crops such as paddy, maize, cotton, soybean and oilseeds, as India remains heavily dependent on the south-west monsoon, which accounts for over 70% of its annual precipitation. "Timely arrival of monsoon would help farmers start sowing on time, potentially raising rural disposable income," said Kalyan Goswami, director general, Agrochem Federation of India. advances towards Kerala First published in February 2007 to serve as an unbiased and clear-minded chronicler of the Indian Dream. RAVI KRISHNAN (EDITOR) - Responsible for selection of news under PRP Act, @ All rights reserved. Reproduction in whole or in part without written permission of Publisher is prohibited; PUBLISHED/PRINTED BY MANHAR KAPOOR ON Printed at HT Media Ltd presses at •Plot No. 8, Udyog Vihar, Greater Noida, Distt Gautam Budh Nagar, Uttar Pradesh 201306; •MNSPrinters Pvt. Ltd, 345/4, Bhatrahalli, Near KR Puram RTO, Old Madras Road, Bangalore 560049; •Saraswati Print Factory Pvt. Ltd, 789, Chowbhaga (W), Near China Mandir, Kolkata 700 105; •MNSPrinters Pvt. Ltd, 76/1, Poonamallee High Road, Velappanchavadi, Chennai 600077; • Bhaskar Print Planet, Survey No. 148P, Changodar Bavla Highway, Sanand (Tal), Distt Ahmedabad, Gujarat. •Jagati Publications Ltd, Plot No. D75 & E52, APIE Industrial Estate, Balanagar, Rangareddy Distt. Hyderabad 500037; *Also available in Pune. RNI Registration DELENG/2007/22485; Mint welcomes readers' responses to all articles and editorials. Please include

Media Ltd All Rights Reserved

Page 7: Prudential to buy 75% in Bharti Life for Rs 3,500 cr / Easing of IPO size rule / VC exit trends / ICEYE chooses India DEALS, TECH & STARTUPSMONDAY, 18 MAY 2026 Prudential to buy 75% in Bharti Life for ₹3,500 cr UK insurer will acquire the stake from Bharti Life Ventures and 360 ONE Asset ManagementAgnidev Bhattacharya Mumbai The Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) granted a rare concession in troubled times: the freedom to reduce a public offering by half without re-filing paperwork. A month later, there are few takers for it. Sebi introduced the rule in April, allowing companies to cut the fresh issue component of initial public offerings (IPO) by up to 50%, earlier there was a 20% limit, without resubmitting their Draft Red Herring Prospectus (DRHP), which generally takes about 75 days. As reported on 15 April, Sebi introduced the rule change to assist capital mobilisation during market volatility linked to the West Asia war. The facility, which followed a regulatory extension for the validity of IPO observation letters, was conveyed to the Association of Investment Bankers of India and is valid for IPOs opening on or before 30 September this year. But investment bankers and legal advisers say issuers have not evinced interest. The reason is that the current IPO market is only interested in valuations.

Companies would prefer not to proceed with IPOs than raise less money at a price that does not align with their calculations. "We have not seen issuers exploring this option as of now," said Sourav Modi, partner at law firm JSA. "Indian markets have an Easing of IPO size rule finds few takers as valuations remain key. Sebi allowed companies to cut IPO fresh issue sizes by up to 50% without refiling draft papers, versus the earlier 20% limit. REUTERS appetite for deals which match their pricing expectations. We have seen big-ticket InvITs (Infrastructure Investment Trusts), Reits (Real Estate Investment Trusts) and IPOs being massively oversubscribed in the last four weeks, and none of them reduced

their size by more than 20%," he explained. For instance, three consecutive mainboard IPOs of Bagmati Prime Office REIT, OnEMI Technology Solutions, and Citius Transnet Investment Trust, were subscribed 25, 10, and 20 times, respectively, without the need to reduce their offer size. "The 50% flexibility acts as a buffer, but executing a reduction of that scale can affect investor confidence regarding demand," a dealmaker at a Mumbai-based investment bank explained, wishing to remain unnamed since they are not authorized to speak to the media. "For our large mandates, we are currently focusing on matching institutional pricing demands rather than resizing capital requirements. If pricing aligns with market expectations, then the current liquidity pipeline will remain sufficient to absorb transactions without downsizing," this investment banker said. India's public offer pipeline currently has a few big IPOs whose DRHPs have already been filed. These include SBI Funds Management Ltd, InCred Holdings Ltd, Manipal Health Enterprises Ltd, Sterlite Electric Ltd, and UPL arm Advanta Enterprises Ltd. prioritizing valuations over raising smaller amounts of capital at lower prices via IPOs. Anshika Kayastha Mumbai UK-based Prudential Plc on Sunday said it plans to pick up a 75% stake in Bharti Life Insurance and subsequently cut its holding in ICICI Prudential Life Insurance to 10%, marking a major realignment of its

India strategy. The investment is part of Prudential's "strategic repositioning of its India operations," the company said in a statement. It will buy the stake from Bharti Life Ventures Pvt. Ltd and 360 ONE Asset Management for ₹3,500 crore. The deal also includes a potential additional consideration of ₹700 crore, subject to the fulfilment of certain

Monsoon advances towards Kerala

/ Two-wheeler safety norms / FASTags for toll-exempt vehicles / Govt digitizes green nod / Straight Forward column 02MONDAY , 18 MAY 2026 CORRECTIONS AND CLARIFICATIONS Mint welcomes comments, suggestions or complaints about errors. Readers can alert the newsroom to any errors in the paper by emailing us, with your full name and address to It is our policy to promptly respond to all complaints. Readers dissatisfied with the response or concerned about Mint's journalistic integrity may write directly to the editor by sending an email to Mint's journalistic Code of Conduct that governs our newsroom is available at FOR ANY QUERIES/DELIVERY ISSUES chemicals in drug making Pharmacopoeia commission crafts new standards incorporating green chemistry principles posed measures expected to increase prices by ₹800-1,000 per unit for installing sensors on handlebars, at least two industry executives said. The move marks a fresh push by the Centre to tighten two-wheeler safety norms even as The shift towards a green pharmacopoeia is expected to have a broad impact on public health by ensuring a cleaner manufacturing cycle. BLOOMBERG Ayaan Kartik & Manas Pimpalkhare Youngsters riding bikes at high speed without hands on the handlebars and performing stunts have long been a common sight in India, raising serious safety concerns for both riders and other motorists and even pedestrians. This could soon change. The government is planning a three-layer "hands-free" safety system for two-wheelers, requiring manufacturers to install technology that can detect whether riders have both hands on the handlebars and step in if they do not, amid rising road accidents in the country.

According to an internal draft of the proposal, reviewed by Mint , the planned safety standards would require bikes and scooters to prevent ignition without both hands on the grip, issue audio and visual alerts if hands are removed while riding, and gradually slow down the vehicle in such cases. The introduction of new standards will lead to additional costs for automakers, which are typically passed on to consumers, with the pro-its attempt to mandate anti-lock braking systems (ABS) across all categories of two-wheelers irrespective of engine capacity remains stuck amid industry resistance and cost concerns. Mint first reported in July last year that the Centre had begun working on a plan to curb hands-off driving in two-wheelers. "There have been deliberations with the government on this where we have discussed a range of features that can be introduced on two-wheelers. The Automotive Industry Standards Committee has prepared a set of regulations and test procedures to crack down on people removing hands while driving," the senior executive cited above said on the condition of anonymity. "Any price increase could have an adverse impact on demand, especially when coupled with an increase in fuel prices. However, regulations that do not lead to an adverse sticker shock could see a lower impact on demand," said Ashim Sharma, senior partner and business unit head at Nomura Research Institute Consulting and Solutions, India. Consultations between the government and automobile manufacturers in 2025 on increasing road safety involved discussions about whether the industry could introduce features on vehicles to reduce accidents, at a time when the government had indicated its view to mandate the use of ABS, Mint reported in July 2025. AISC works under the aegis of the ministry of road transport and highways and prepares standards, which are then approved by Central Motor Vehicle Rules Techni-

cal Standing Committee. ayaan.kartik@live-mint.com The government is planning a three-layer 'hands-free' safety system for two-wheelers. MINTSubhash Narayan The Centre is developing a separate category of FASTags for toll-exempt vehicles as part of its nationwide rollout of barrier-free highway tolling under the Multi-Lane Free Flow (MLFF) regime, according to two people aware of the matter. The proposed system is expected to allow exempted users, including armed forces personnel and certain government agencies, to pass through toll corridors

without being charged or flagged for violations, the two people said. The move is aimed at addressing a key challenge in India's shift to artificial intelligence (AI)-enabled tolling systems, where every vehicle passing through a toll point must be digitally identified and recorded. Mint had earlier reported on the government's plans to shift to MLFF tolling, which uses AI, satellite-based tracking and automatic number plate recognition systems to collect tolls electronically while vehicles continue moving at high speeds. But the system creates compliance challenges for creating a centralized database of exempted vehicles with the ministry of road transport and highways (MoRTH), enabling back-end integration with the tolling system. The second involves issuing dedicated FASTags carrying unlimited free-pass privileges to authorized agencies, the second person cited above said. Queries sent to MoRTH, the National Highways Authority of India and the defence ministry remained unanswered till press time. Former defence and road transport secretary Giridhar Aramane said the government had already conducted pilots involving exempted institutions such as the armed forces, police and paramilitary agencies, where vehicle databases were integrated with tolling

systems for smooth passage. "The new system brings about challenges for toll treatment of private vehicles used for official purposes that are also in the exempted category. Either details of these vehicles can also be shared with MoRTH or the ministry could issue special FASTags with infinite free movement," he said. The move is aimed at addressing a key challenge in India's shift to AI-enabled tolling systems. ISTOCKPHOTO exempted categories such as defence, paramilitary, and police vehicles. Any unregistered or unrecognized vehicle movement through toll points could automatically trigger e-challans or penalties even in cases where the vehicle is legally toll-exempt. Exempted vehicles could carry specially configured FASTags capable of automatically registering vehicle movement without deducting toll charges, the first person said. Official military vehicles, however, may not require FASTags at all. Their movement through tolling points could instead be tracked through recognition of special defence number plates, with the associated movement data deleted immediately afterwards for security reasons, the person added. To address the issue, the government is evaluating two approaches. One involves sharing—Under the proposed system, every vehicle passing through a toll point will be digitally identified and recorded. Vijay C. Roy & Manas Pimpalkhare The government has digitised the compliance process for environmental clearances linked to industrial expansion, in a move aimed at easing regulatory burdens and accelerating project

approvals, said two officials aware of the development. The ministry of environment, forest and climate change has made the process of obtaining certified compliance reports for industrial expansion proposals digital through the existing PARIVESH portal, aiming to ease procedures for businesses seeking environmental clearance. Launched in August 2018, PARIVESH (Pro-Active and Responsive facilitation by Interactive, Virtuous, and Environmental Single-window Hub) is a central government digital platform, which automates and streamlines the process for businesses and developers to apply for and track mandatory environmental and ecological clearances. The online system will enable industries to file compliance reports pertaining to projects where environmental clearance is needed, upload mandatory documents and track approval status through a single digital platform, reducing paperwork and procedural delays, the officials said, requesting anonymity. "It will be useful for those projects which require environmental clearance. The move will benefit medium and large scale industries as the entire process can now be completed online. Once all the documents are uploaded, ministry officials will conduct on-site inspections and geo-tag the premises, a move that is also expected to enhance transparency in the system," said the first official cited above. nod for projects The move is aimed at easing regulatory burdens and accelerating project approvals, said two officials. Priyanka Sharma

The Centre is set to clamp down on the use of harmful chemicals and energy-intensive processes in the pharmaceutical industry—a sweeping regulatory shift that will alter how medicines are tested and manufactured in its \$50 billion drug market. The Indian Pharmacopoeia Commission (IPC) is crafting new standards for drug making and testing by using green chemistry principles, which are essentially guidelines to reduce or eliminate hazardous substances. The commission is the health ministry's apex body responsible for setting the standards for drug making and testing in India. A key objective is to replace carcinogenic class-1 solvents such as benzene, chloroform and carbon tetrachloride with water or other safer class-3 solvents, two people aware of the matter said on condition of anonymity. The commission has started with high-volume categories, one of the two people said. “The IPC has already updated approximately 25 monographs within the IP (Indian Pharmacopoeia) 2026 edition, focusing on high-volume categories such as anticancer, antihypertensive and antibiotic drugs. It is now working on an additional 50 monographs under this 'green' framework to further expand the initiative,” the person said. A monograph outlines the tests a drug must pass to prove its identity, purity, and strength before it can be sold. The shift towards a green pharmacopoeia is expected to have a broad impact on public health by ensuring a cleaner manufacturing cycle. It also assumes significance for global medicine use, given that Indian companies supply 20% of the world's generic medicines and account for 60% of global vaccines. Apart from India, these standards are also followed in 14 more countries—Afghanistan, Ghana, Nepal, Mauritius, Suriname, Nicaragua, Bhutan, Mozambique, the Solomon Islands, Sri Lanka, Nauru, Malawi, Guyana and Fiji. “The IPC is working on environmental sustainability and ecofriendly standards. If these methods are adopted into the IP, hundreds of manufacturers across India will cumulatively save thousands of litres of hazardous solvents,” the second person

said. The IPC is also utilizing research and innovation to optimize testing processes. By reducing the number of procedural steps and shortening testing times—for instance, achieving results in five hours rather than 10—the commission aims to save significant resources and energy. “These changes are meticulously evaluated to ensure that drug quality remains uncompromised and results remain reproducible. The initiative also extends to the physical and digital footprints of the commission. The IPC has already moved toward a digital-first IP to reduce paper consumption and is now transitioning its Indian Pharmacopoeia Reference Substances (IPRS) packaging to fully recyclable materials, the second person said, adding the new standards will also limit the flow of discarded toxic chemicals into soil and water. Queries emailed to a health ministry spokesperson remained unanswered. The Indian Pharmaceutical Alliance (IPA), which represents 23 leading pharmaceutical companies, welcomed the move. “The IPA has consistently advocated for integrating green chemistry and scientifically validated alternatives to animal testing into regulatory frameworks. To ensure seamless adoption, the implementation of these methodologies must remain science-driven, globally harmonized, and pragmatically phased. This approach will guarantee analytical consistency, reproducibility, and cross-border regulatory acceptance, while upholding the highest standards of drug quality, safety, and efficacy,” secretary general Sudarshan Jain said. Other countries that also follow Indian standards Freedom can never be taken for granted. It always requires awareness, strength and austerity. I invite all of you to whatever religion or party or group you may belong to as comrades in this great struggle that has been forced upon us. I have full faith in our people and in the cause and in the future of our country...” Jawaharlal Nehru gave this speech on All India Radio on 22 October 1962 after China's attack. There was a massive response by the people to his call to action. The secessionist movement in Tamil Nadu stopped. In one Rajasthan village, 250 families pledged to send their sons to the army. All strikes and movements were suspended. Women bought wool from the money saved in their piggy banks, rice canisters or trunks to knit sweaters for soldiers. My mother was one of them. Many women

donated their mangalsutras to the government treasury for military equipment purchases. Among those donating was Nehru's only child, his daughter, Indira Gandhi. She donated her entire jewellery weighing 367gm to the war fund. Within three years India faced another tough test. In 1965, US

President Lyndon B. Johnson delayed our wheat supply. In response, Prime Minister Lal Bahadur Shastri appealed to his countrymen to forgo meals once a week to save grain. I was in primary school. I remember that on Tuesday evenings flatbread and a simple vegetable would be cooked for us children. My parents and grandfather would observe a fast. Today, when the entire world is suffering due to the crisis in West Asia, I am once again reminded of the 1973 embargo in the region. Relations deteriorated between the Gulf countries and the US. It led to an energy supply breakdown. For India, those were tough times. Indira Gandhi had to raise the price of petrol from ₹1.60 per litre to ₹2.75 per litre. The Centre's budget that year was termed the 'Black Budget'. The country suffered an unprecedented loss of ₹550 crore. The war with Pakistan, the influx of refugees from Bangladesh, the 1972-73 drought and a surge in defence spending strained both the government and its citizens. What a strange coincidence that the meteorological department has predicted a below-normal monsoon this year and the Gulf crisis has set oil prices on the boil. There's a world of difference between the situations of 1973 and today. Then, there were just 650,000 motor vehicles in India. Today, the number stands at 400 million. At that time, only 4,055km railway was electrified and 80% of the trains ran on coal or diesel. Today, electrification of railways is near 100% and diesel engines are maintained just for strategic use. Despite these gains, the needs of 1.4 billion people have surged. Energy demand today is many times higher than in 1973. As a result, the petrochemical industry's daily loss has crossed ₹1,000 crore. Yet, the government kept petrol and diesel prices in check, raising them only marginally on Friday. India is the only nation providing free rations to 800 million. This comes at a time when the rupee is hitting record lows against the dollar and euro amid weakening global trade. Energy prices may rise further in the near future. It is difficult to understand the criticism when Prime Minister Narendra Modi is urging restraint in energy use, advising a pause on gold purchases and discouraging unnecessary foreign travel at a time like this. I don't want to waste my time on politicians and their politics. Their tone changes according to the tide of time. In 1962, our country faced extreme challenges due to Chinese aggression. At the time, Atal Bihari Vajpayee was sharply criticising Nehru's policies in Parliament. Later, he reflected on his stance and, during the 1971 Bangladesh War, praised Indira Gandhi as "Durga." The same Vajpayee later became prime minister. Even today, he's considered a beacon of Indian politics. But other leaders didn't learn any lessons from him. During 1962, '65 and '71, those who attacked the Congress are now in power and the Congress is in the opposition. Now, their leaders are attacking the Bharatiya Janata Party. The way politics has panned out leaves everyone sad. How can our politicians change their stance with such consummate ease? It's unfortunate that their conduct is leading to dismay. In 1999, when the forces were moving during the Kargil conflict, there was no one at railway stations offering them packed food chanting "Bharat mata ki jai". Between 1962 and 1971, the same society would chant patriotic slogans when trains with soldiers would pass. The partisan narratives seen during Operation Sindoor felt like a warning of what may lie ahead. Are we drifting towards declining patriotism and a weakened collective conscience? If yes, can the trend be reversed? Shashi Shekhar is editor-in-chief, Hindustan. Views are personal. How can our politicians change stance with such consummate ease?

STRAIGHTFORWARD SHASHI SHEKHAR IS INDIA'S NATIONAL UNITY SLOWLY WEAKENING? Respond to this column at Vijay C Roy India's weather office on Sunday said conditions are turning favourable for the further advance of the south-west monsoon over parts of

the south-east Arabian Sea, south-west and south-east Bay of Bengal, the remaining areas of the Andaman Islands and Andaman Sea, and parts of the east-central Bay of Bengal over the next two to three days, even as large parts of north and central India brace for intensifying heatwave conditions. The south-west monsoon is likely to reach Kerala on 26 May, close to its normal onset date of 1 June, according to the latest forecast by the India Meteorological Department, which has projected a model error margin of four days on either side. Last year, the monsoon reached the Kerala coast on 24 May. A timely monsoon is critical for kharif sowing, especially for crops such as paddy, maize, cotton, soybean and oilseeds, as India remains heavily dependent on the south-west monsoon, which accounts for over 70% of its annual precipitation. "Timely arrival of monsoon would help farmers start sowing on time, potentially raising rural disposable income," said Kalyan Goswami, director general, Agrochem Federation of India.

advances towards Kerala First published in February 2007 to serve as an unbiased and clear-minded chronicler of the Indian Dream. RAVI KRISHNAN (EDITOR) - Responsible for selection of news under PRP Act, @ All rights reserved. Reproduction in whole or in part without written permission of Publisher is prohibited; PUBLISHED/PRINTED BY MANHAR KAPOOR ON Printed at HT Media Ltd presses at •Plot No. 8, Udyog Vihar, Greater Noida, Distt Gautam Budh Nagar, Uttar Pradesh 201306; •MNSPrinters Pvt. Ltd, 345/4, Bhatrahalli, Near KR Puram RTO, Old Madras Road, Bangalore 560049; •Saraswati Print Factory Pvt. Ltd, 789, Chowbhaga (W), Near China Mandir, Kolkata 700 105; •MNSPrinters Pvt. Ltd, 76/1, Poonamallee High Road, Velappanchavadi, Chennai 600077; • Bhaskar Print Planet, Survey No. 148P, Changodar Bavla Highway, Sanand (Tal), Distt Ahmedabad, Gujarat. •Jagati Publications Ltd, Plot No. D75 & E52, APIE Industrial Estate, Balanagar, Rangareddy Distt. Hyderabad 500037; *Also available in Pune. RNI Registration DELENG/2007/22485; Mint welcomes readers' responses to all articles and editorials. Please include

Media Ltd All Rights Reserved

Page 7: Prudential to buy 75% in Bharti Life for Rs 3,500 cr / Easing of IPO size rule / VC exit trends / ICEYE chooses India DEALS, TECH & STARTUPSMONDAY , 18 MAY 2026

ICEYE chooses India for first Asia-Pacific satellite hub

VCs adapt to non-IPO exits as pragmatism trumps prestige Exit playbook Investors are relying more on secondaries and M&A deals as volatility delays technology IPOs. *Data as of 15 May 2026

Source: Venture IntelligenceSecondary VC transactions in India (2020-2026) 22 44 31 47 45 51

11No. of Deals Amount (\$ billion)Startup M&A transactions in India (2020-2026) Year 2020 2021

2022 2023 2024 2025 2026*0.5 3.4 1.6 1.5 1.5 1.1 0.455 108 322 243 162 214 84No. of Deals

Amount (\$ billion) 2.5 9 7.3 3.5 8.2 6.7 5.9

MANU CHOUDHARY/MINT Curefoods, Turtlemint, Indo- MIM, Inframarket, and KKR-backed Leap India are recalibrating timelines Prudential Plc currently owns about 22% in ICICI Prudential Life Insurance through its partnership with ICICI Bank. MINT Manyinvestorswant growthbutalsofear volatility.Hybrid fundsdeliverexactlythat. Theyaredesignedtofollow abalancedapproachb y investinginamixofequity, debt,andsometimes even goldorotherassets. MrInvestor:lunders tand equity funds and debt funds ,butwheredoh ybrid fundsfit in? Mr Mutual Fund:Hybrid fundssitrightinthemiddle. Theycombinegrowth- orientedassetslikeequity withonesthatofferincome generation,likedebt.This blend helps smooth out volatility.When equity marketsfluctuate,the debt portion cushionsyour portfolio.Whenmarketsrise, theequityportioncaptures thegrowth. Hybridfundsarepowerful becausetheyhandleasset allocationforyou.Thefund managerdecidestheright mixdependingonmarket conditions,ensuringyour portfolio remainsbalanced withoutyouhavingto monitororadjustitconstantly. These fundsareespecially helpfulfornewinvestors, thosewithmoderate tohigh-riskappetite.Tounderstand therangeofhybridfunds better,asimple breakdownisgiven inthetablebelow. MrInvestor:Isaw a videoclaimingthat hybridfunds do n't performas wellas pureequityfunds. Isthis true? Mr .Mutual Fund: Thestrengthofhybrid fundsis diversification of investment across assetclasseslikeequity,debt, gold/silveretc.Theyprotect yourdownside duringmarket falls while still participating in growth phases.Social mediaoften oversimplifies

investing,muchlikeself- diagnosing from online videos.Foryour money,always rely on SEBI-regulated professionals andnot unverified online content. MrInvestor:So, hybrid funds are safer than equity funds? Mr Mutual Fund:They arerelativelymorestable becausetheirdebt component,buttheystill carryequitymarketrisk.The advantageissmoother returns andreduced emotional stress,makingthemidealforlong-term- focusedinvestors. MrInvestor:Should I consider Systematic InvestmentPlans(SIPs)in hybrid funds too? Mr Mutual Fund: Absolutely.SIPsworkwell acrossallcategories,and hybridfundsarenoexception. Theyhelpyouinvest consistently,reduce timing risk,andmakeyourjourney evensmoother. Hybridfundsareagreat choiceforanyoneseeking balancebetweenriskand returnandgrowth.Theyoffer diversification,expert- managedasset allocation, andamorecomfortable investingexperience.MINTMEDIAMARKETINGINITIATIVE Embracingdiversificationwithhybridfunds MrandMs InvestorMrMutual Fund Typeof HybridFund AggressiveHybrid Funds BalancedHybridFunds ConservativeHybrid Funds DynamicAsset AllocationFunds MultiAssetAllocation FundsEquityAllocation 65%-80% 40%-60% 10%-25% Changesbasedonmarketconditions (0%-100%)Suitability Investorsseekinglong-termgrowth Moderate-riskinvestors Investorsthatwantlimitedequityexposure andpredominantexposuretodebt Investorswantingmarket-driven adjustments Investorswantingdiversificationin asinglefund

Mutual Fund investment is subject to market risks,read all scheme related documents carefully. Disclaimer:KnowYourCustomer (KYC):It ismandatory to complete KYC process before investing in Mutual Funds (MF).For this,submit the complete KYC Form at any Asset Management Company (AMC) branch or nearest Point of Service (POS)

orthroughafinanc ialadvisor.ForKYCForm, cl icklink:<https://www.canararobeco.com/wp-content/uploads/2025/02/cr-central-kyc-registry-application-form-individual.pdf>.IfyouwouldliketoupdateanyKYCinformation(address,contactdetailsetc.),submittheKYCFormwithupdateddetailsatyour nearestAMCbranch orPOS.CheckKYCstatusatKnowYourStatus (www.karvykra.com).ForchangeofbankdetailsregisteredwithanyMF,downloadbankmandatechange formfromthatMF'swebsite,andsubmittheformtothatMF'sbranches orOfficialPointsofAcceptance.SEBI Registered MutualFunds:Investorsshoulddeal onlywith registered MutualFunds,details ofwhich canbeverifiedontheSEBIwebsiteunder"Intermediaries/MarketInfrastructureInstitutions"at<https://www.sebi.gov.in/intermediaries.html>.ComplaintRedressal:Forcomplaints,contacttheInvestorServiceDepartmenttotherespectiveMF(forcontactdetails,referschemerelateddocumentsofMFs).Incase,theinvestorisnotsatisfiedwith theresolution,theinvestorcancomplainonSCORESplatform(SEBI ComplaintsRedressSystem)atHome-scores.sebi.gov.in.Forcases,wheretheinvestor is notsatisfied with theresolutionbyAMC/MF or through SCORES, the investorcancomplainonlineDisputeResolutionPortal("ODR Portal")at<https://smartodr.in/login>.ThismaterialisapartoftheInvestorEducationandAwareness InitiativebyCanaraRobecoMutualFund.

Debt Allocation	20%-35%	40%-60%	75%-90%	Changesdynamically	(0%-100%)
Atleast3assetclassesincludingequity,debt,goldand/or silveretc(Minimum10%acrosseachassetclass)					

Page 8: Mark to Market S&P BSE Sensex CLOSE 75,237.99 1-MONTH CHANGE (%) -3.65 6-MONTH CHANGE (%) -10.84 1-WEEK CHANGE (%) -2.70 3-MONTH CHANGE (%) -8.91 1-YEAR CHANGE (%) -7.66 Nifty 50 CLOSE 23,643.5 1-MONTH CHANGE (%) -2.40 6-MONTH CHANGE (%) -8.54 1-WEEK CHANGE (%) -2.20 3-MONTH CHANGE (%) -7.12 1-YEAR CHANGE (%) -4.42 Nifty 500 CLOSE 22,531.15 1-MONTH CHANGE (%) -0.26 6-MONTH CHANGE (%) -5.22 1-WEEK CHANGE (%) -2.53 3-MONTH CHANGE (%) -3.26 1-YEAR CHANGE (%) 0.05 Nifty Next 50 CLOSE 69,280.25 1-MONTH CHANGE (%) 1.09 6-MONTH CHANGE (%) -0.10 1-WEEK CHANGE (%) -3.09 3-MONTH CHANGE (%) 0.98 1-YEAR CHANGE (%) 6.28 Nifty 100 CLOSE 24,572.15 1-MONTH CHANGE (%) -1.78 6-MONTH CHANGE (%) -7.10 1-WEEK CHANGE (%) -2.37 3-MONTH CHANGE (%) -5.73 1-YEAR CHANGE (%) -2.61 S&P BSE Mid-cap CLOSE 16,197.1 1-MONTH CHANGE (%) 2.26 6-MONTH CHANGE (%) -1.70 1-WEEK CHANGE (%) -2.65 3-MONTH CHANGE (%)

1.14 1-YEAR CHANGE (%) 5.25 S&P BSE Small Cap CLOSE 6,685.19 1-MONTH CHANGE (%) 4.70 6-MONTH CHANGE (%) -2.14 1-WEEK CHANGE (%) -3.81 3-MONTH CHANGE (%) 5.33 1-YEAR CHANGE (%) 3.52 Mark to Market writers do not hold positions in the companies discussed here unless otherwise informed al Oswal Financial Services), that for Muthoot expanded from 11.3% in Q4FY25 to 13.4% in Q4FY26. But for investor sentiment, much depends on whether Muthoot can sustain its good run. The first concern is that much of the growth came from higher gold prices. Active customer base declined 1.8% sequentially in Q4FY26, market, even as demand for gold loans may fade amid increasing availability of unsecured loans with reducing stress. Competition can weigh on yields, too. While Muthoot's gold loan yields expanded to 20.8% in Q4FY26 after selective price hikes of 0.5-1%, part of this was aided by non-recurring income, including interest recoveries from legacy NPAs. With rising borrowing costs amid competition, yields can be expected to normalize. As for asset quality, gross non-performing assets (NPAs) improved to 2.34% in March 2026 from 3.35% a year ago, but worsened sequentially. While stage-2 and stage-3 assets expanded, that was largely driven by Reserve Bank of India-mandated (RBI) borrower-level classification changes. Moreover, at 57-58% LTV, the management insists they are comfortably recoverable. But a moderation in gold prices can flip this narrative by hurting loan growth,

increasing LTVs, and consequently, worsening asset quality. While one school of thought expects gold price momentum to sustain on continued central-bank buying amid global geopolitical tensions, and the recent doubling of import duties, risks are emerging from rising bond yields and strengthening US dollar. On the bright side, RBI has removed the need for prior approval for branch expansion by large gold loan non-banking financial companies (NBFCs). Muthoot plans to add 400- 500 gold-loan branches, including those under Belstar. This matters as gold lending is relationship-

driven, and operationally intensive, where Muthoot believes it edges out competition. "Higher gold prices, LTV headroom and branch expansion should support growth which coupled with operating leverage should drive 15% EPS CAGR, 25% ROE over FY26-28," said Jefferies India's analysts. So far, so good. But the management's FY27 AUM growth guidance stands at 15%, a sharp moderation from FY26's eye-watering pace. Muthoot's nearly 60% stock return over the past year already reflects its premium positioning, and markets may no longer reward headline growth alone. MARKET HEAT WITH rising borrowing costs amid competition, yields are likely to normalize. COMPETITION is a key overhang, with low-cost lenders entering the gold loan market. Srushti Vaidya MUMBAI As higher oil prices, foreign outflows and slowing corporate earnings growth weigh on markets, Indian investors may need to temper expectations from equities, according to Nilesh Bharkhada, chief investment officer at Kotak Pension Fund. In an interview with Mint, Bharkhada said rising capital costs could pressure valuations further, while crude oil above \$100 a barrel may trigger cuts to earnings and growth estimates. Edited excerpts: The government has hiked petrol and diesel prices. Which sectors are the most impacted? How is it going to affect the broader macro environment? The current price hikes are modest compared to the sharp rise in crude oil prices. Elevated crude prices will either be absorbed by the government, if it expects prices to normalize soon, or passed on to consumers in a staggered manner. Either scenario

would be inflationary. Rising petrol and diesel prices will directly impact sectors such as travel and tourism, fast-moving consumer goods (FMCG) and other discretionary segments. More broadly, economic growth could come under pressure as a sharp rise in inflation affects consumer demand. Inflation inched up in April. Do you see rising crude prices and El Niño pushing inflation higher? Which companies are likely to be most impacted by higher input costs? INTERVIEW Foreign portfolio investors (FPIs) have sold cash shares so far in 2026, almost equal to what they sold in all of 2025. Is this concerning? Foreign portfolio investors (FPIs) have sold aggressively during previous risk-off phases as well, so the trend by itself is not necessarily concerning. However, India runs a current account deficit and relies on foreign capital flows to help manage its balance of payments. The West Asia conflict is also widening India's trade deficit, and sustained FPI outflows are adding pressure on the currency, which is a concern in the current context. What could be the impact on earnings if crude stays above \$100 a barrel? Earnings recovery was already under pressure before the West Asia conflict. What changes now? Markets were positioned for a swift resolution to the West Asia conflict, but the tensions have persisted for a couple of months, pushing crude prices above \$100 a barrel. Broader market valuations have corrected as FPI outflows continued. However, crude oil above \$100 a barrel is not factored into base-case market estimates and could lead to downward revisions in earnings and growth projections. Should investors lower

their expectations from equities now? Yes. As the cost of capital rises, equity valuations will adjust lower. Corporate earnings growth has also moderated in recent years, which means investors may need to temper their return expectations. India's PE multiples are falling, but earnings estimates are also being cut. Are valuations really becoming attractive? India's valuation multiples have corrected meaningfully over the last 18-24 months. Valuations for large-cap companies are

now at or below their long-term averages. Mid- and small-cap stocks, however, continue to trade at a premium, although bottom-up opportunities are available in select pockets at reasonable valuations. Economic growth could come under pressure as a sharp rise in inflation affects consumer demand. Nilesh Bharkhada, Chief investment officer at Kotak Pension Fund, "The inflation trajectory is turning upward, with the Wholesale Price Index (WPI)-based inflation for April rising to 8.3%. However, the pass-through to consumers is yet to fully materialize, with retail inflation at 3.48%. Food inflation has remained subdued for a considerable period and has been a key factor in keeping overall inflation under control. However, the India Meteorological Department has forecast below-normal monsoon rainfall this year, which poses an upside risk to food inflation. Higher crude prices and weather-related disruptions could increase input costs across sectors, particularly for companies with high dependence on energy and commodity-linked raw materials. Oil marketing firms, building materials companies and consumer discretionary players

are likely to be among the most impacted. Which sectors are you currently comfortable with? We remain positive on private banks, the energy value chain, defence, commodities and information technology, including platform companies. What are the key risks for markets? India has remained an attractive investment destination and has commanded premium valuations primarily because of its relatively strong growth outlook. Geopolitical risks remain persistent, and India needs to ensure adequate measures are taken to build a more sustained, self-reliant and resilient growth story amid evolving global dynamics. Fiscal profligacy also remains a key risk, and India should continue to focus on fiscal prudence and capital expenditure over the medium term to maintain macroeconomic stability. 'Investors may need to temper return expectations as capital costs rise' Ram Sahgal & Srushti Vaidya MUMBAI The government's decision to curb silver bar imports could push exchange-traded funds (ETFs) tracking the white metal from trading at a discount to moving into a premium over spot prices, after two weeks, amid concerns of an impending supply squeeze, analysts said. This would mark a shift from ETFs trading at a discount to net asset value (NAV), which is calculated from spot prices, to potentially trading at a premium. It implies that if spot prices rise, ETF prices could rise more, and if spot prices fall, they would fall less than the spot. Premiums and discounts typically reflect demand conditions. When demand for ETF units is weak, they

trade below NAV or MCX spot-linked silver prices. When demand strengthens, they can flip into a premium. Under normal conditions, ETF prices track NAV closely. But sharp swings in investor demand can cause temporary misalignment. For instance, the most popular silver ETF, Silver-Bees, traded at ₹249.85 per unit as of Friday, about 1.3% below its then NAV of ₹253.12, reflecting subdued demand. That discount, analysts said, could quickly flip into a premium in the event of a rush in amid fears of a shortage of investment-grade silver following the government's curbs. On Saturday, the government moved silver bars from the "free" to the "restricted" import category to rein in demand and conserve forex. Imports will now require a government licence. Bullion dealers supplying asset management companies (AMCs) source a large part of silver bars from banks, which have sought clarity on whether they will also need licences to import on a consignment basis after the Saturday order. "Until now banks were authorized by the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) to import gold. Now, we have sought clarity from the DGFT (Directorate General of Foreign Trade) on whether lenders will need a licence," said a banker from a private bank's bullion desk. "Silver ETFs traded at an average discount of ₹7,000 per kilo to MCX spot rates over the past fortnight," said Satish Dondapati, fund manager at Kotak Mahindra AMC. "They could move into a premium if investors believe sufficient silver

may not be available for investment purposes after the government order.” Dondapati added it was too early to estimate the extent of any potential premium. The import curbs come as the government responds to pressures on India’s current account deficit (CAD) and the rupee amid the West Asia war. ram.sahgal@live-mint.com of the story, go to live-mint.com Import curbs may raise silver ETF demand On Saturday, the government moved silver bars from the ‘free’ to the ‘restricted’ import category Bullion dealers supplying asset management companies source a large part of silver bars from banks REUTERS glomerate has committed annual capital expenditure of over ₹2 trillion over the coming five years across its 10 listed companies and numerous unlisted businesses incubated under Adani Enterprises Ltd. It reported combined earnings before interest, tax, depreciation and amortization of over ₹92,000 crore in the first nine months of fiscal year 2026 (FY26) across the group. According to one of the two people cited above, the conglomerate will oversee research and development and finance, and retain intellectual property rights on manufacturing designs and others. Initially, the group will ensure its partners’ profitability and establish offices and staff housing closer to its sites. It will also transfer its workforce to vendors where required, like in the case of manufacturing units or ground handling operations at ports, for a smooth transition. A large number of site-level employees have been shifted to vendors in recent months, while many more are expected to follow. The employees continue to be part of “Adani’s extended enterprise environment,” the person cited above said, implying the transition won’t change

their working conditions. “Our endeavour is to work FROM PAGE 1 with a selected group of strong and reliable partners who can take responsibility for the entire task and complete it better, faster, and more effectively,” chairman Adani said in an address on Labour Day earlier this month, when he broadly outlined a transformation plan based on three pillars. “This is a change in mindset; this is a change in culture,” he said. The Adani Group did not respond to Mint’s request for a comment. Experts confirmed the ongoing global shift to a vendor-heavy model to improve scale and capital efficiency through third-party ecosystems, rather than directly owning every operational layer. “It is encouraging to now see large Indian conglomerates making a similar strategic transition with growing confidence and sophistication,” said Monish G. Chatrath, managing partner of MGC Global Risk Advisory, a risk management advisory firm. However, he cautioned that such models have potential risks too. It becomes more challenging to ensure sound corporate governance across a decentralized ecosystem of contractors and service providers, he said. “The most material exposures in such structures arise around third-party cyber vulnerabilities, ESG and labour compliance across vendor chains, concentra-“The three-layer model aims to flatten the organization so that responsibility is clear and decisions can be made quickly,” Adani said in the same speech. Multiple reporting layers are being compressed into each other to create a wider reporting span, with the intention of cutting down the layers between decision centres and decision makers, the two people said. “The three-layer structure is that you have a head office layer, you have a site layer, and you have the direct shop floor layer. This means the shop floor layer can speak to the head office directly,” the first person quoted above said. “This requires a redesign of how HR works.” Chatrath said that promoting internal talent carries l